was expected, the absence of all 29 BJP MLAs was significant. Rumours of a lack of nod from the party high command in New Delhi were doing the rounds.

The absence of politicians was an embarrassment for Sinha. "This double standard will not benefit Jammu and Kashmir," he said at the gathering made up of government officials. "It's a reality that J&K is a UT today and members have taken oath and affirmed their allegiance to the Constitution. When it becomes a state, we will celebrate a statehood day."

Though NC won 37 of its 42 seats in the Valley and the BJP secured all its 29 seats from Jammu, reflecting the UT's divergent polities, both regions want statehood restored.

NOT ONLY DID NC, PDP AND CONGRESS LEGISLATORS GIVE THE UT FOUNDATION DAY EVENT IN SRINAGAR A MISS, NOT ONE OF THE BJP'S 29 MLAS ATTENDED IT

In his second cabinet meeting, Omar's government reverted to the traditional academic session of October–November in the Valley from the March–April one started by the UT administration in 2022 to bring J&K's academic calendar in sync "with the rest of the country". He also warned the bureaucracy against "exploiting the loopholes in the governance model" under the UT status. A senior NC leader and MLA attributes these bold steps to the "assurance" Omar received in New Delhi. "The meeting was very cordial," he says. The PM and home minister "assured full support" to Omar on statehood and development, he adds.

A full-fledged statehood will return governmental control over the J&K Police and some security matters. Currently, security falls under the domain of the Union home ministry, with the lieutenant governor replacing the CM in unified command—comprising J&K Police, paramilitary, army and intelligence services—meetings. Many have noted the spiralling terrorist attacks in J&K in recent weeks coinciding with the emergence of two power centres. Since October, the series of attacks has resulted in 15 casualties, including seven migrant workers at the strategic Z Morh tunnel, and two army soldiers in the Gulmarg sector.

Sinha and Omar have yet to share a public stage since the elected government assumed charge on October 16. The Kashmir Marathon, which saw nearly 2,000 athletes running on Srinagar's roads on October 20, was flagged off by the CM in the morning, with Sinha presiding over a felicitation event later. That has set a template. Foundation day celebrations of the Islamic University of Science and Technology at Awantipora on November 7 used to be a daylong event. This year, they have stretched on for a week. According to sources, the CM and education minister Sakeena Masood Itoo are expected to visit on November 11 or 12, while the LG who serves as the chancellor will preside over the final-day function on November 13, marking the end of 'Foundation Week'. ■

DOCTORS' DEATHS

A SILENT CRISIS

Amid rising cardiac deaths among young physicians, a look at the crisis relating to doctors' health in India—and what it takes to protect our protectors

By Sonali Acharjee



LONG WORKING HOURS

A 2020 study that surveyed junior residents at MGM Medical College, Mumbai, had some alarming findings

64%
Worked for around 81-100 hours per week

58%
Got just 6 hours of uninterrupted sleep per day

74%
Admitted being asked 'quite often' to work over 24 hours continuously

**Multiple studies suggest that a majority of doctors are inclined to informally consult for their personal medical conditions before seeking formal care*

Graphic by NILANJAN DAS & TANMOY CHAKRABORTY